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UNSELLING THE CLASSROOM: CONFRONTING HISTORY AND OURSELVES

Abstract

College educators have a duty to confront the lived realities of white supremacy and settler colonialism as they present themselves in the classroom, the historical record, and the academy at large. This response paper engages with the ideas and experiences presented by the fellow panel authors, and it contemplates the necessary steps needed to counteract the persistence of settler colonial and white supremacist ideologies in post-secondary education from the perspective of a junior historian. By devoting ourselves to the accessibility of educational materials, including diverse interpretations and accounts of the past in our courses, and not shying away from the discomfort that confronting these systems will cause, educators in college settings can work against white supremacy and settler colonialism.

Keywords: *Doctrine of Christian Discovery, colonialism, papal bulls, crusade ideology, international law, Iberian monarchies, Indigenous dispossession*

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Introduction

I am truly honored to have been invited to respond to this panel discussion. Having a professor like Dr. Chaness and an educational environment such as SUNY Oswego, both of which have significantly influenced my ongoing journey in academia and my developing worldview, is one thing; being included in their work is another entirely. The work of Dr. Chaness, Dr. Hurtado, Dr. Duran-Jimenez, and Dr. Radhakrishnan is essential as we envision our collective futures both within and beyond academia. This is especially pertinent as we are living amid historically created political reckonings surrounding the constructions of race, class, and gender.

I graduated with my B.A. in Anthropology with a minor in History from SUNY Oswego in 2022; now I am in the middle of my third year as a Ph.D. student in History at the University at Albany, SUNY, which I could not have done without the guidance of Dr. Chaness, SUNY Oswego. It was here at SUNY Oswego that I truly began to reckon with my privilege of being a white middle-class woman in meaningful ways. I was unsettled when I was confronted with what I had not been taught before college because of my high school's null curricula.[1] It is a privilege to reckon with white supremacy and settler colonialism at the age of 18, while others had this knowledge in their beings from a young age, out of necessity. I decided to continue through the academy to fully understand the capacity of colonial harm, how that violence has shaped the academy, with the end goal of alleviating the effects of the systems, then working to dismantle them.

Project

As of now, my dissertation will discuss the life of the Onöndowa\'ga:\ reservation on the Allegheny River (in what we now know as New York and Pennsylvania), and its residents. Starting with the fight against the construction of the Kinzua Dam during the 1930s-1960s, I will push the analysis back to the eighteenth century- after the Whirlwind, maintaining sovereignty for the Onöndowa\'ga:\ on the Allegheny took innovative paths, ones also pushed by other members of the Confederacy.[2] With this work, I aim to expand the existing scholarship on the Quaker missionary presence among the Allegany Onöndowa\'ga:\, which has been well-documented but deserves further examination as the role of settler colonialism and imperialism has become better understood in the Early American Republic. This work is inherently political in many ways, tracing histories of Indigenous sovereignty and the nature of the settler state and their actions towards the Onöndowa\'ga:\ and Hodinöhsö:ni' largely.

The place of philanthropy in a larger system of settler colonial occupation is central to this project. One of the principal questions of this work is the place of philanthropy in a settler colonial system and society. This necessitates the centrality of land in the story, not only for the

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[1] Radhakrishnan, 5.

[2] Alan Taylor, *The Divided Ground: Indians, Settlers, and the Northern Borderlands of the American Revolution* (Borzoi Book, Alfred A. Knoff, 2006).Taylor illuminates the innovate strategies taken by Oneida and Mohawk leaders (among others) who were navigating a new triad of boundary lines.

improvement-based missions that were established by Quakers who were spottily funded by the United States federal government's Civilization Fund, but also the fact that this innovative sovereignty did not keep the United States Government from viewing Onöndowa\'ga:\ lands as a resource.[3] While we cannot refute the presence of humanitarian and philanthropic intentions on the part of Quaker missionaries, we can consider the lived effects of their presence in Seneca country from the late eighteenth century through the later nineteenth century. If we do so, we may be better able to understand a case study of the role of philanthropic missions with proximity to the settler state and how helpful they truly were.

Kayenthwahkeh (Cornplanter) wrote to the Society of Friends in Philadelphia (Quakers) and asked if they would take on his son Henry and another boy of the same age to educate them as their own and "especially, to teach them to love peace."[4] In their reply, the Quakers noted their willingness to take these boys in and provide them with formal education; they also expressed the approval of Secretary of War Henry Knox and the governor of Pennsylvania in this endeavor.[2] This was for one thing, a reminder of their belonging to a country that had coerced land from their Confederacy and Nation only seven years earlier in the Treaty of Fort Stanwix (1784). Quakers would observe the Treaty of Canandaigua in 1794, and the gifting of the George Washington Wampum Belt, which remains a living testament to Haudenosaunee sovereignty, but at the time was seen by the settler state to ensure peace in the face of war in what would be called the Ohio Country. This observance was only one instance in which Quakers had garnered themselves a reputation for loving peace and being sensitive to the nefarious activities that could occur during treaty negotiations.

When a group of three missionaries came to Genesinguhta (or Cornplanter's tract) and a settlement nine miles north called Junchshadago in 1798 with the aid and endorsement of United States officials, they endeavored to give Onöndowa\'ga:\ people a formal education in English and to implement an Anglo-American farming style. Quakers would soon widen their missionary project to include other Onöndowa\'ga:\ settlements, and they established a more permanent mission in Tunesassa (outside the bounds of the Allegany Reservation) in the early years of the nineteenth century. Tunesassa would become a boarding school in 1852.

With a varying degree of separation from the federal government, Quaker missionaries who intended to do right by the Onöndowa\'ga:\ were upholding the structures that attempted to remove Native women from their roles, Native people from their culture, and their ways of belonging to the land. Yet, Quakers were strident suppoters of protecting Onöndowa\'ga:\ lands from the Holland Land Company in the same century and in the 1950s when the United States government was breaking treaties to construct Lake Perfidy i.e. the Kinzua Dam. Listening to Onöndowa\'ga:\, Haudenosaunee, and Native voices on the importance of land and their relationship is paramount here because settler colonialism or "Indigenous elimination, as a practice and formal policy, continues today, entailing the wholesale destruction of nonhuman

[3] *Lake of Betrayal*, directed by Paul Lamont and Scott Sackett (Vision Maker Media, 2017), Documentary, 56 min, https://www.kanopy.com/en/albany/video/5535683.14:40.

[4] Letter from Cornplanter to Quakers, 1791, Native-Americans and Quakers, 1791-1815, Friends Historical Library, Swathmore College, Misc_mss_1791_06_02.

relations."[5] I cannot, however, look for answers to ecological issues without looking at Onöndowa\'ga:\' women because of their centrality to subsistence and agriculture. I can't scorn the place of Christianity in all of this either even though Quakers were not seeking religious converts, their religious worldview affected the way they saw productivity, gender norms, gendered division of labor, and standards for dress and adornment are all biases that come through in the first round of missionary journals.

Though Onöndowa\'ga:\women are central to this research, they have been removed from archives due to "gendered colonial power."[6] This fact of settler colonialism and white supremacy has led me to listen to Native scholars like Alyssa Mt. Pleasant who notes the importance and detrimental effects of relying too heavily on colonial documents and archives; they are likely to reproduce the same frameworks and language use without critical engagement and reflection. Deploying the "reading against the grain" method has been central to dealing with these sometimes unsettling but necessary documents.[7] In a concerted effort to expand this project's archival basis, I am interested in analyzing archaeological remains already collected from pertinent sites. The material remains of the past, especially those of the mundane, are likely to reveal the complexities of life for those who experienced settler colonialism.[8] Moreover, items can help me situate this story according to Onöndowa\'ga:\ temporalities and geographies to bypass another trap of settler-colonialism.[7]

Whether it be for this project or another, in the future, I want to do work in the service of Native communities when and if they desire it from me. I have had the honor and joy to get to know a Nation fighting for its federal recognition status while doing research for their case. Dr. Chaness has taught me that sustained reciprocal relationships in the gift economy are more appropriate than academic extraction techniques of the profit economy, as our academic ancestors did. Non-Native historians (and other scholars) who work must work with extant communities when possible so that we are concretely discomforted by the things we see in the archives and embedded in accepted historical narratives. History, as it has been written in the past, has sparsely served Native and Indigenous communities in the ways that it should, but this can be corrected when historians look beyond themselves and to the communities they write about.

An Unnerving Political Climate

For the past year, the United States has seen an uptick in blatant censorship: scrubbing national museums and websites of "anti-American" ideologies. Public libraries are being targeted by citizens who parrot white supremacist talking points out of fear for the perceived loss of power that would come with having diverse representations of human experience readily available for

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[5] Nick Estes, *Our History Is the Future : Standing Rock versus the Dakota Access Pipeline, and the Long Tradition of Indigenous Resistance*, (London ; Verso, 2019), chapter 3.

[6] Maeve Kane, *Shirts Powdered Red: Haudenosaunee Gender, Trade, and Exchange across Three Centuries.* (Cornell University Press, 2023), 13.

[7] Alyssa Mt. Pleasant et al., "Materials and Methods in Native American and Indigenous Studies: Completing the Turn," *Early American Literature* 53, no. 2 (2018): 407–44, https://doi.org/10.1353/eal.2018.0044.

[8] Rae Gould et al., *Historical Archaeology and Indigenous Collaboration: Discovering Histories That Have Futures* (University Press of Florida, 2020).

public consumption.[9] Institutions of higher learning are being poised to show their true colors when the promise of federal funding is held over their head, only to be revoked if they support their communities and Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion initiatives. International Student Visas were revoked for a group of SUNY students. Mahmoud Khalil and other pro-Palestinian activists who existed on a college campus have been abducted and detained for their morals. Freedom of speech is being shot down for more people than it already was. The rise of migrant people being abducted from their homes and workplaces without warrants, and citizens will be next. Simultaneously, we're seeing a rise of human-induced climate crises and threats to ecological and public health in areas surrounding newly constructed data centers.[10] These concerning incidents all have their roots one way or another in White Supremacist thought.

There has been both organized and informal resistance to the ideas of white supremacy and settler colonialism since they arrived on this continent. Yet, we are all still wrapped up in its ever-constricting binds. I think we are approaching, if not already amid, societal reckonings that will insist in one way or another on the dismantling of white supremacy and its equally wretched kin, settler colonialism. As a person with a privileged positionality (white, middle-class, settler person), I feel it is particularly imperative to help in this process; taking it one step further, I feel it is the task of white people in general to do the heavy lifting to end the practices that entrench the tenants of white supremacy culture. Equally so, settler descendants and doubly the academic ones like myself, need to actively rebuke and correct the harm done by white academics in the past and those who uphold it today. I have some responsibility to the land I inhabit and the people who have stewarded it since time immemorial, to act in alignment with them.

White supremacy culture seeps into the educational environment when it favors quantity over quality of work, sees progress as linear and constantly increasing rather than cyclical and variable, when we fall into the trap of claiming objectivity, and when instructors shy away from discomfort.[11] As an educator of history, these and other white supremacist land mines riddle the field, but those teaching history must remain steadfast in teaching the realities of white supremacy, offering up diverse sources and voices that interrupt and complicate popular narratives steeped in white supremacist rhetoric. History continues to be weaponized to support erroneous and harmful narratives, when figures entrusted to running the country uphold false myths of Indigenous cannibalism and human sacrifices, they are not only lying, but they are also reaffirming the falsehoods used to excuse Native American dispossession, removal, and erasure. So, in fraught times, what should historians and educators of history do?

A Discomforting Education

I aim to embrace and utilize the political nature of history, education, and teaching people about history, to the chagrin of some, I'm sure. Like Dr. Radhakrishnan, I too know that the perspectives I include in my classes, the words I use, and the way that I navigate discomfort are political acts.[12] In addition to engaging with diverse sources in order to piece together the past, I

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[9] *Moms for Liberty*, "About," accessed January 15, 2026, https://www.momsforliberty.org/about/

[10] Lauren Dalban, "A Data Center Could Be Coming to an Upstate New York Town, and Residents Are Speaking Out," *Inside Climate News*, November 8, 2025, https://insideclimatenews.org/news/08112025/lansing-new-york-data-center-development/

[11] Muthuki, *Characteristics of White Supremacy Culture*, accessed January 15, 2026, https://www.whitesupremacyculture.info/characteristics.html

[12] Radhakrishnan , 1

ask students about what they have learned about a topic before this class and why they think they learned it in such a way. I ask them to compare disparate perspectives and narratives to help them understand the interpretative nature of history. What they feel is the accepted or widely used narrative behind an issue, and how a certain historical moment could still be playing out in the present. Rather than remembering the dates or names of historical events that is typical of high school education, I want my students to learn, at the very least, that the past is a complicated place that is bound up in historical contexts and current uses. I frame the analyses I facilitate around what is called "the 5 Cs of Historical Thinking"- change over time, context, causality, contingency, and complexity- to help students think about the sources presented by the professor.[13] Still, more importantly, it is an efficient way to get students to remember how to think critically about information pushed to them in their daily lives after they leave class.

In the same vein, when I conduct my own courses, the first week will be dedicated to understanding the process of history using excerpts from Michel-Rolph Truoillot's *Silencing the Past: Power and the Production of History*. According to Trouillot, "Silences enter the process of historical production at four crucial moments: the moment of fact creation (the making of *sources*): the moment of fact assembly (the creation of *archives*): the moment of fact retrieval (the making of *narratives*): and the moment of retrospective significance (the making of *history* in the final instance)." I only engaged with this monograph in grad school, and it has aided me greatly in my own research as I search for the archival presence of Indigenous Onöndowa\'ga:\ women; I only wish I had engaged with it sooner, if I had read it in an undergraduate history class, I would have had a better idea of the field of history itself and the knowledge I had acquired until that point. If undergrad students, even those who were only there to fill a gen-ed requirement, had this understanding, they could continue to confront historical narratives as they confront them beyond the classroom. You don't need to be a historian to be able to understand how "...any historical narrative is a particular bundle of silences, the result of a unique process,..."[14] Or why white supremacy can and does create silences in the historical record that need to be acknowledged and then removed.

Furthermore, I embrace the political nature of educating by asking students about their concerns in current affairs, which allows me and the leading professor to better adjust our discussions to the needs of students who will leave our classrooms and may never have another history course. In the fall semester of 2025, students often said they're interested in environmental issues- knowing this means that I can incorporate kernels of environmental history into the survey course. Interpreting primary sources from invading European settlers who catalogued the "new" natural world around them doesn't end on the point of settlers wanting to know what they could find where but also wondering why they wanted to extract the things they did. Simple forays into the lack of resources in Europe (like the depletion of lumber) expand and complicate their thinking from a simple idea of "gold, God, and glory" being the cause of European colonization and asks them to think of how settlement and colonization have altered the environment they invaded. Similarly, the period of the Market Revolution in the early nineteenth century caused large alterations to the landscape, the resources it provided, and the more-than-human lives it supported. If students answered my question with an answer about the current state of politics, I

[13] Thomas Andrews and Flannery Burke, "What Does it Mean to Think Historically?", A*merican Historical Association* 45(1), 2007, published digitally 2024. https://www.historians.org/perspectives-issue/january-2007/

[14] Michel-Rolph Trouillot, *Silencing the Past: Power and the Production of History* (Beacon Press, 1995). 26 and 27.

would try and highlight the long legacy of political division in the United States throughout its lifetime.

When it comes time for me to design my own courses, rather than seeing the system of invasion that depends on extractive economies as a product of time or a consequence of natural processes, I will complicate the narrative and show the complexities of the past. My main focus will be entering knowledge from Native and Indigenous people when available, not only textual sources but material ones as well. For an AHIS 100 class (usually American History from the colonial era to the Civil War or Reconstruction), I would include writings from contemporary Native writers like the women featured in *Native American Women's Writing, c.1800-1924: An Anthology*, David Cusick (Tuscarora), Maris Pierce (Onöndowa\'ga:\), William Apess (Pequot), Wampum Belts, other nonsensitive material culture, as well as current writing, conversations, struggles/wins, and art in conversation with the past.[15] I will also denounce the settler-colonial periodization of history on this continent when possible. Instead of defining the eras of pre-contact Native Americans as "prehistory,"[16] I will emphasize the importance of oral traditions as they describe the networks of trade, kinship, and diplomacy that connected Native American groups before Europeans invaded and that settler colonial systems did not end but only altered these longstanding relationships.

As a student who was deeply unsettled by the past, I know that some of the information being presented can trigger discomfort. When discomfort arises, I make space for students to fully grapple with it through reflection and acknowledgement. I redirect the class to those who made changes in the past to remind us of all that change is possible with knowledge, community, and action. Yes, the past is unsettling, but our future does not have to be that way when we understand the past for what it is for everyone and what it can become. When the time comes, I will use journal entries to help create a more open and reflexive learning environment. The first reason is the different kinds of energy it requires. While the importance of critical thinking and engagement with sources cannot be disputed, I know that doing so without critical reflection compromises the retention of what's being learned. As a student of Dr. Chaness, I was able to use my journal entries as a tool to make sense of the content; a lot of it being things that I hadn't a clue about before getting there, and it begged me to change the way I saw the world. This is part and parcel of teaching hard subjects, those that demand unsettlement and discomfort. Many aspects of American history make us uncomfortable, whether people like to admit it or not; for students confronting that for the first time, someone needs to recognize the discomfort, nurture it, and challenge them to keep going. Like Dr. Hurtado mentions:

> As we move through these different writings, I remind students that there will be moments when they feel discomfort with what they read or even moments when they reject what the authors are sharing. I ask them to mark where those moments of discomfort/rejection happen, and to sit with the feeling and write down why they are having that reaction. I discuss with them why this step is important, and that it is necessary even if doing it means they cannot complete the full reading assignment.[17]

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[15] Karen Kilcup, ed. *Native American Women's Writing, c. 1800-1924 : An Anthology*, Oxford, UK ; Blackwell Publishers, 2000. And Alan Michelson, *Hanödaga:Yas (Town Destroyer)*, 2018, https://www.alanmichelson.com/handagayas.

[16] Juliana Barr, "There's No Such Thing as 'Prehistory': What the Longue Durée of Caddo and Pueblo History Tells Us about Colonial America," *The William and Mary Quarterly* 74, no. 2 (2017): 203–40.

[17] Hurtado, 9.

I, too, will value the critical engagement of students with their own understandings of history over the typically valued recitation of the assigned reading. If we do not confront the discomfort felt when reading literature, documents, and other accounts of the past, we cannot, as a collective, dismantle white supremacist understandings of history. When engaging critically with disparate sources, it will be important that my students have the basis of knowledge presented by Trouillot. When we keep in mind just how historical narratives come to be, the discomfort those narratives bring can be better situated and explained; our best paths forward seem clearer.

However, facing discomfort is not only a task for our students, but it is also our duty to overcome the discomfort we face as educators. As Dr. Duran-Jimenez states:

> One of the most critical areas for addressing white supremacy in higher education is within the curriculum itself. Many academic disciplines, including those in the humanities and social sciences, have historically been shaped by white, Western perspectives (Crenshaw, 2024; Turner, et al., 2024). Faculty play a critical role in helping to transform curricula and provide educational content that is transparent, historically accurate and transformative. This process often requires uncomfortable conversations and a willingness to confront one's own biases and positionality. As educators, however, it is our responsibility to confront these issues directly; it does not serve education or the interests of our students to shy away from discomfort, but rather live in it.[18]

One day, in the Spring semester of 2024, a student of color aptly corrected me when I mentioned that sexual violence was a weapon used by white terrorist organizations against Black women and girls. In this statement, I silenced the experiences of Black men and boys who were also victimized in such a gruesome manner. I thanked her for helping me understand this. I could have let the discomfort of correction overtake me, but I bypassed this perceived right to comfort and accepted that my statement was wrong, and that the experiences and knowledge of my students is invaluable to my skills as an instructor and a better member of our community.

Institutionalized racism and inequality have material manifestations; Dr. Duran-Jimenez provides an excellent understanding of what making a more "equitable and inclusive classroom" will look like in practice. I plan to do as Dr. Duran-Jimenez does and "…In an effort to develop a more equitable and inclusive curriculum, I teach all my classes as a Zero Textbook Cost (ZTC) or Open Education Resources (OER) course. All of my materials are available through open-source and are updated regularly to reflect the most current frameworks."[19] While current textbooks provide helpful resources for students and provide instructors a platform to check for understanding, I need further convincing on their usefulness. Even now, there is a concerning lack of students who have the textbook for my current TA assignment; I always bring my textbook to class and encourage the students without a copy to use it and to come to my office hours to do the same. Being excluded from the conversations in the classroom because a student cannot afford the material reinforces the economic manifestations of white supremacist systems. When instructors require money for the education they provide, they are ensuring that students from historically and currently marginalized groups will not have the same access to knowledge that other, more privileged students have. But in the end, this method serves all students by alleviating the financial barriers of education, so it is truly democratic.

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[18] Duran-Jimenez, 2.

[19] Ibid,, 6.

Similarly, I will try to design my courses to be smartphone accessible for the students who cannot get access to a personal or library computer for whatever reason. Websites such as the Internet Archive, Project Gutenberg, and Hathi Trust only require an account (by using their school email) to be created in order to access their digital materials and can be easily accessed on a mobile device. College libraries often give students access to platforms like ProQuest, Kanopy, Project Muse, and JSTOR, providing eBooks, PDFs of journal articles, and documentaries. I have been lucky enough to work with professors who have relied on documentaries as source material for American History courses, the most notable of which is *Slavery By Another Name*, written by Sheila Curran Bernard (SUNY Albany) adapted from Douglas A. Blackburn's monograph of the same title.[20] In the era of digital media, it can be easier to convince a student to watch something- even if they are doing something else that needs to be done, like cleaning or laundry, rather than sit down to read. Similarly, podcasts will be a staple in my classes as they are accessible for users and to students with different learning styles. Furthermore, the availability of this equipment has facilitated BIPOC people sharing knowledge they are willing to with a wide audience on their own terms.[21]

Conclusion

In the academy as well as in our wider world, white supremacy and its culture must be uprooted and its repercussions healed. Within academia, educators can do this by creating an equitable and accessible learning environment by eliminating or limiting the monetary burden on students, preparing our students to live and participate in a democracy comprising of diverse peoples, cementing diverse perspectives in our classes, and finally by encouraging and practicing critical reflection when met with discomfort. This is not an exhaustive list, though; this process will need to be revised, reimagined, and redirected. Collaboration across disciplines and outside of the academy will be crucial in this inevitable process. I am grateful to be entering the academy with seasoned professionals who have begun this work already.

My teaching philosophy as of this moment is to create an environment based on mutual respect and understanding, one that allows students to ask questions about how history happened, so they can continue to ask questions about why things are the way they are today. To do this, I must understand where students are at throughout the semester by taking feedback, appreciating students' lived experiences when they feel comfortable including it in their work, and trying to incorporate their interests when possible. If I expect students to listen to me, how can I be expected not to listen back? I look forward to the growth I will undergo to better serve my students, the communities whose pasts I study, and the larger community in and around campus.

I have struggled with imposter syndrome during my time as a Ph.D. student, fearing I am not good enough to be where I am, coupled with the anger and dread I feel when thinking too long about the political climate- these feelings are hard to overcome. Moving forward, when I feel inadequate, when I think I should just take the easier route of dropping out, I will remember Dr.

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[20] Sam Pollard, Laurence Fishburne, Douglas A Blackmon, film distributor Public Broadcasting Service, and production company TPT National Productions, *Slavery by Another Name*. Arlington, VA: Public Broadcasting Service, 2012. And Douglas A. Blackmon, *Slavery by Another Name: The Re-Enslavement of Black Americans from the Civil War to World War II*, first edition (New York: Anchor Books, a division of Random House, Inc.), 2009.

[21] A notable inclusion here is Matika Wilbur and Temryss Lane, *All My Relations*. Podcast, 2019-present, https://www.allmyrelationspodcast.com. Podcasts from the New Books Network are great ways to digest the main points of an academic monograph.

Hurtado's reaction to that same feeling of n: "Something in my soul revolts. Even in moments of despair, I just...*can't*. I have to confront these messages for what they are: lessons of colonial oppression. Holding on to my belief in learning allows me to challenge the feeling of failing. "[22] I will refuse, refuse to uphold white supremacy and settler colonialism, refuse to feel there is no hope in fighting these systems, and refuse to stop these endeavors.

[22] Hurtado, 12.